check against Islamizing impulses taking root among the wider population. Deobandis represent a minority of Sunni Muslims in Pakistan, and the Ahl-e-Hadith an even smaller one. Despite their minority status, they are the two Islamic schools of thought to which Pakistan's major jihadi groups belong. Whereas multiple militant outfits adhere to the Deobandi school of thought and share a common ancestry as well as connections to the Taliban, Lashkar is the only major Ahl-e-Hadith jihadi group.

Deobandis are the second largest bloc within Pakistani Sunni Islam, but the most prolific in terms of political agitation and the promotion of militancy. However, at its inception the movement was apolitical. Deobandi Islam originated in 1867 in the Indian town of Deoband, approximately 100 miles north of Delhi. There a group of clerics founded the Darul Uloom Deoband, a school dedicated mainly to teaching the Hadith—the text that transmits the path or traditions of the Prophet Mohammad—and opposed to rational studies based on human reasoning.[49] It was one of a number of Islamic revivalist movements sweeping British India at a time when Muslims were the primary targets of a crackdown launched in response to the failed Rebellion of 1857 against the British Empire. While the early Deobandis opposed British rule, they were mainly 'inward-looking and primarily concerned with the Islamic quality of individual lives.'[50] Twelve years after the first Deobandi madrasa was founded, eleven more had opened across British India. Soon these seminaries were attracting a number of Afghan students as well.[51] Today, Deobandis have their strongest following among Pashtuns in Balochistan, the NWFP and FATA, all of which abut Afghanistan.[52] However, institutional links between Deobandi seminaries in Afghanistan and Pakistan and those in India were severed as a result of Partition.[53]

Prior to Partition, the Deobandi ulema were divided over whether to support the call for a separate state (Pakistan) by Mohammad Ali Jinnah and the Muslim League. The pro-Muslim league faction became the Jamiat Ulema-e-Islam. Many Deobandi clerics who opposed the creation of Pakistan moved there anyway following Partition, and joined the JUI. So too did many of the Deobandi ulema already living in what became Pakistan, but who initially had opposed the country's formation. Although the JUI had little political influence in Pakistan at Partition, as it was still intended to be a religious movement, it soon transformed into a political